

Signs of an unhealthy relationship

An unhealthy relationship doesn't usually start out that way. It often begins with a small insult that's in the gray area of what's appropriate and becomes more abusive, and sometimes violent, over time. It is only usually once both people are invested in the relationship that the abuse, be it physical or emotional, becomes apparent. Pay attention to early warning signs.

Isolation from loved ones

Discouraging a person from seeing loved ones is a way of controlling them. It isolates them from their support network.



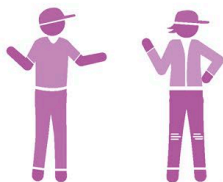
Emotionally demanding

Needing a lot of comfort and demanding attention can be emotional abuse and denies a person private time.



Guilt trips

An abuser makes a person feel like they've done something wrong in order to justify their abuse and to have an excuse to punish the person.



Short fuses

Anger can be emotionally manipulative, especially if the abuser blames the other person for that anger. Sometimes, it can become physical abuse.



Why people stay

It is very easy to say, "I would never allow myself to be treated that way," but there are lots of reasons that can make it hard for someone to walk away from a bad relationship. Sometimes, the people in the relationship just don't recognize that it's unhealthy, even if it seems obvious from the outside. At other times, people stay because they think it will get better.



TEEN HINTS

Supporting a friend

If a friend is in an unhealthy relationship, you may notice they become withdrawn from their friends over time. They may show signs of depression, low self-esteem, and fearfulness. Even if your friend denies there's a problem, they need to know that you will be there for them. Try to be understanding, and seek help if you're worried for your friend's safety.

Seeking help

Leaving an unhealthy or abusive relationship can be incredibly hard, but it is not impossible. Finding a network of emotional and practical support is critical to the process.

PARENT TIPS

How to help

If your teen is in an abusive relationship, intervening may seem like the only option, but it could push your teen away from you, as they struggle for autonomy, and back to the abuser.

- Ensure your teen knows that you will always support them, without judgment, no matter what.
- Seek support from your community and your teen's community about whether or not to intervene.